THE KIDS AREN'T ALRIGHT

Forever hunched over screens, city children in India are falling prey to 'adult' diseases. The solutions? A return to the outdoors, healthier eating and enough sleep

By **SONALI ACHARJEE**

Ritu Malhotra's heart breaks every time her 12-year-old son Aarav (name changed) trudges back home after football practice instead of hanging out with his friends are ordering burgers. Aarav was diagnosed with Grade 1 fatty liver disease—the initial stage of Non-alcoholic Fatty Liver Disease, a complication associated largely with adults. Aarav must thus avoid oily food, and his 42-year-old Delhi-based banker mother finds tough to explain why a child his age must say 'no' to social situations built around food.

In many urban Indian homes, there is a preponderance of illnesses that are assailing children between the ages of five and 12. "Compared to 10–15 years ago, we are seeing far more children with asthma, obesity, allergies, digestive problems and even physical manifestations of stress," says Dr Chirag Tandon, director, internal medicine, ShardaCare-Healthcity in Greater Noida. "It means reduced quality of health starts from a younger age now." The villains of the series playing out in every other home are a sedentary lifestyle, gorging on junk food, reduced time spent outdoors, increasing screentime, lack of sleep....

Maladies that Blight Kids

Serious illnesses afflicting children aged 5-12, the reasons why and roads to recovery

OBESITY

Urban childhood obesity prevalence in India is at around 9 per cent, according to a 2024 report

SYMPTOMS: Rapid weight gain, fatigue, low stamina

CAUSE: Processed food, excessive screen time, low physical activity, poor sleep

TREATMENT: Weight-management programmes, glucose monitoring, medication

CURE: Regular movement, reduced junk food, outdoor play

FATTY LIVER DISEASE

Studies say fatty liver disease may affect up to 40–70 per cent of obese children in India

SYMPTOMS: Fatigue, abdominal discomfort

CAUSE: High processed food and sugar intake, sedentary lifestyle

TREATMENT: Liver scans, metabolic screening, hepatology care, treatment of obesity, insulin resistance

CURE: Weight management, exercise, dietary changes

ASTHMA & ALLERGIES

Asthma prevalence among Indian children was estimated at 7.9 per cent in *Lung India*

SYMPTOMS: Wheezing, cough, sneezing, breathing difficulty

CAUSE: Pollution, indoor living, low microbial exposure

TREATMENT: Smart inhalers, nebulisation, desensitisation therapy, newer biologic injections

CURE: Early diagnosis, cleaner environments and regular treatment

CONSTIPATION/ GUT PROBLEMS

Among the most common reasons children are brought to clinics

SYMPTOMS: Stomach pain, bloating, irregular bowel movements

CAUSE: Low-fibre diets, dehydration, inactivity, high screen time

TREATMENT: Bowel retraining programmes, paediatric gastroenterology care, gut motility medications

CURE: Fibre-rich food, hydration, physical activity